

MK PARRISH · MKPARRISH.COM

# THE BRAND VOICE PLAYBOOK



*Build a brand voice document from scratch.*

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BY MK PARRISH · \$45

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# INTRO: WHY MOST BRANDS SOUND LIKE A GROUP PROJECT

Read ten company About pages back to back and you will feel it, the same warmed-over confidence, the same "we're on a mission to revolutionize," the same nobody-actually-talks-like-this sheen. Most brands do not have a voice. They have a committee average. Three people wrote it, four more sanded the edges off, and what is left is the verbal equivalent of beige carpet.

A real brand voice is a decision. It is the difference between a company that sounds like a company and one that sounds like a person you would want to know. And it does not come from inspiration, it comes from a document. A specific, opinionated, written-down set of rules that anyone on the team can follow to sound like one consistent human.

This playbook builds that document from scratch. We will define the voice foundation, map your tone across situations, build do-and-do-not vocabulary lists, capture a real voice from a founder's own mouth, roll the whole thing out to a team, and even teach an AI to hold the line. Then I will walk you through two complete worked examples for invented companies so you can see every piece assembled in two very different registers. By the end you will have a template you can fill in for any brand, yours or a client's.

This is the premium, roll-up-your-sleeves one. Have a notebook or a doc open. At the end of each chapter there is a short **Build It** step that produces one finished piece of your actual document, so that by the last page you are not holding notes, you are holding a voice guide. We are building something you will use.

“

*Brand voice is not decoration you add at the end. It is a decision you make at the start about who you are when you open your mouth.*

## CHAPTER ONE: VOICE VS. TONE (GET THIS RIGHT OR NOTHING WORKS)

People use these interchangeably. They are not the same, and confusing them is why most voice work falls apart.

**Voice is constant. Tone is contextual.**

Your voice is your brand's personality, fixed, recognizable, the same whether you are announcing a launch or apologizing for an outage. A person does not get a new personality every morning. Neither does a brand.

Tone is how that voice flexes to fit the moment. A confident, warm brand is still confident and warm in an error message, but the tone dials down the playfulness and up the reassurance. Same voice, adjusted tone.

The analogy: voice is the instrument; tone is what you play on it. A cello is always a cello. It can play a funeral or a flirtation. Your brand should be that recognizable and that flexible at once.

If you only define voice, your team will not know how to handle a refund email. If you only define tone case by case, you will drift into a different personality every week. The document we are building covers both, and the difference between voice and tone is the hinge the whole thing swings on. Get it wrong and you will either sound robotic, the same chirpy register during an outage as during a launch, or you will sound unstable, a different personality depending on who happened to be typing. Get it right and you sound like a real person having a range of real moods while remaining, unmistakably, themselves.

**Build It:** Write one sentence defining, for your brand, the one thing that must never change across every situation. That is the seed of your voice. Everything else flexes around it.

## CHAPTER TWO: THE VOICE FOUNDATION FRAMEWORK

Before vocabulary, before tone, you decide who the brand *is*. Four components. Answer each in writing, vague answers here poison everything downstream.

### *1. The Voice in One Sentence*

Force the whole personality into a single line. "We sound like a sharp, generous mentor who has seen it all and roots for you anyway." If you cannot write the sentence, you do not know the voice yet. Keep drafting until it is true.

### *2. The Three-to-Five Traits*

Pick a handful of personality traits, and crucially, define each by what it *means* and what it *does not* mean. "Confident" is useless alone. "Confident: we state things plainly without hedging; this does NOT mean arrogant or dismissive" is usable. The "does not mean" clause is where you prevent the trait from being misread into something off-brand.

This single move, the "does not mean" clause, is the most important technique in this entire book. Every trait has a shadow, the version of it that goes wrong. Confident curdles into arrogant. Friendly curdles into unprofessional. Witty curdles into flippant. Bold curdles into reckless. If you name only the trait, you have handed your team a word that points in two directions at once, and on a busy day they will pick the wrong one. The shadow clause draws the border, and a voice is defined far more by its borders than by its center.



### 3. The Brand's Beliefs

What does this brand think is true that others in its space will not say? Voice without conviction is just style. The beliefs give your writers something to **stand on**, not just a way to sound. List three to five.

### 4. The Human Comparison

Finish the sentence: "If our brand were a person, it would be \_\_\_\_, but not \_\_\_\_." ("A favorite professor who makes hard things click, but not a stuffy academic." "Your most honest friend, but not the one who is mean and calls it honesty.") This gives writers an instant gut-check.

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*A trait without a "does not mean" clause is a trait waiting to be misinterpreted. Define your voice by its borders, not just its center.*

**Build It:** Draft all four components for your brand. The one-sentence voice, three to five traits each with a shadow clause, three to five beliefs, and the human comparison. This is the heart of your document; spend real time here.

# CHAPTER THREE: TONE SPECTRUM MAPPING

Voice is set. Now map how it flexes. A tone spectrum is a set of sliders your brand moves along depending on the situation.

Define your brand's range on four spectrums. For each, mark where your *default* sits, then note how it shifts in specific contexts.

| SPECTRUM              | ONE END             | OTHER END      |
|-----------------------|---------------------|----------------|
| Formal / Casual       | Boardroom           | Group chat     |
| Serious / Playful     | Solemn              | Winking        |
| Reserved / Bold       | Understated         | Declarative    |
| Warm / Matter-of-fact | Arm around shoulder | Just the facts |

Now map tone to situations. This is the table that saves your team:

| SITUATION                | WHERE THE SLIDERS MOVE                             |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Marketing / launch copy  | Bolder, more playful, full warmth                  |
| Onboarding & education   | Warm, slightly more formal, patient                |
| Error & outage messages  | Serious, matter-of-fact, still warm; never playful |
| Billing & legal          | Formal, clear, reassuring; zero cleverness         |
| Customer support replies | Warm, casual, bold enough to take ownership        |
| Bad news / apologies     | Serious, plain, humble; cut all marketing language |

The rule that holds it together: **the voice never changes, only the tone.** A playful brand does not crack jokes during an outage, but it is still recognizably itself, just turned to its serious, warm setting.

A quick way to pressure-test your tone map: take your boldest, most playful piece of marketing copy and your most serious outage message, and read them back to back. They should sound like the same person on a great day and a hard day, not like two different companies. If they sound like strangers, your voice is not yet constant; you have defined two voices and called them tones.

**Build It:** Fill in both tables for your brand. The situation-to-tone table is the page your team will reference most; make it specific to the situations your brand actually faces.

## CHAPTER FOUR: DO AND DO-NOT VOCABULARY LISTS

This is the most-used page in any voice doc, because it is the most actionable. You are building a working dictionary: words and phrases that are on-brand, and ones that are banned.

Build four lists.

**1. Words We Use.** The vocabulary that sounds like you. Verbs especially, voice lives in verbs. ("Build, sharpen, decide, cut, earn.")

**2. Words We Avoid.** The dead phrases and off-brand words. Be specific and a little ruthless. ("Synergy, leverage, robust, seamless, revolutionary, passionate, journey, unlock, game-changer.")

**3. How We Say Common Things.** Take recurring messages and write the on-brand version. This is where consistency actually happens:

| INSTEAD OF                            | WE SAY                                        |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| "We apologize for any inconvenience." | "That's on us. Here's how we're fixing it."   |
| "Please don't hesitate to reach out." | "Questions? Just ask, we read every message." |
| "We're excited to announce..."        | "It's here. Here's why it matters to you."    |
| "Our innovative solution..."          | (describe what it actually does)              |

#### 4. Grammar & Mechanics Calls.

The small consistency decisions: contractions yes or no (almost always yes, they are how humans talk), Oxford comma, sentence-case or title-case headers, emoji policy, exclamation-point budget. Boring, essential, and the thing teams fight about forever if it is not written down.

“

*A brand voice document is only as strong as its examples. "Be friendly" is a wish. A swap table is a tool.*

#### Build It:

Start all four lists now, even if rough. The "How We Say Common Things" swap table is the highest-value page in the whole document; seed it with the five messages your brand sends most often.

## CHAPTER FIVE: CAPTURING VOICE FROM A REAL PERSON

Everything so far assumes you know what the voice should be. Often you do not yet; it is locked inside a founder's head and only comes out when they stop trying to sound professional. Voice capture is how you get it out.

This is the part agencies charge the most for and explain the least. Here is the actual method.

**Interview for stories, not adjectives.** Never ask a founder "what are your brand values?" You will get a thesaurus. Ask instead: "Tell me about a customer you loved working with. What did you say to them?" "What is the advice you give that nobody in your industry agrees with?" "What makes you roll your eyes when competitors say it?" People reveal their voice when they are telling a story or defending a conviction, never when they are describing themselves in the abstract.

**Record it and read the transcript, not your notes.** The gold is in the exact phrasing, the throwaway line, the way they said the thing before they cleaned it up. Notes lose that. A transcript keeps it.

**Mine the transcript for three things.** Recurring phrases, the words and images they reach for again and again. Their natural rhythm, do they speak in short punches or long rolling sentences. And the moments of conviction, the places their energy spiked, because that is where the beliefs live.

**Reflect it back and watch their face.** Draft the one-sentence voice and a few traits from the transcript, read them aloud to the founder, and watch. When you nail it, their face changes; they say "yes, that's exactly it."

That flash of recognition is the signal you have captured the real voice and not invented a plausible one.

The whole goal of capture is that the finished document does not sound like a branding exercise. It sounds like the founder on their most articulate day, written down so the rest of the team can borrow it.

**Build It:** Write your five voice-capture interview questions, tailored to your brand. If the brand is a client's, schedule the interview. If the brand is you, answer the five questions out loud, record yourself, and transcribe it. Then mine your own transcript for the three things above.

## CHAPTER SIX: A COMPLETE WORKED EXAMPLE — TIDEWATER & CO.

Theory is done. Here is the whole document, filled in for a company I made up so you can see every piece working together. **Tidewater & Co.** is a fictional financial planning firm for self-employed creatives, freelancers, artists, and founders who are great at their craft and terrified of their own taxes.

### *The Voice Foundation*

**Voice in one sentence:** Tidewater sounds like the financially fluent friend who explains money without making you feel stupid, calm, candid, quietly funny, always on your side.

#### **Traits:**

- **Plainspoken:** we explain money in language a human uses. This does NOT mean dumbed-down or condescending.
- **Reassuring:** we lower the reader's blood pressure. This does NOT mean falsely cheerful or dismissive of real fear.
- **Candid:** we tell the truth about money, including the uncomfortable parts. This does NOT mean blunt to the point of cold.
- **Quietly witty:** a dry line where it earns its place. This does NOT mean jokey, meme-y, or unserious about people's livelihoods.

#### **Beliefs:**

- Financial anxiety usually comes from confusion, not numbers. Clarity is the actual product.
- Creative people are not "bad with money." They were handed money advice written for salaried nine-to-fives and told they failed it.



- Shame is the enemy. Nobody made a good financial decision while being lectured.

**Human comparison:** Tidewater is the friend who is a CPA and actually fun at dinner, but NOT the smug finance bro, and NOT the doom-and-gloom advisor who makes you want to never open a bank statement again.

## *The Tone Spectrum*

Default sliders: leaning casual, mostly serious with room for dry wit, bold in our convictions, high warmth.

| SITUATION                             | tone shift                                                |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Website / marketing                   | Warmest and boldest; wit allowed; lead with relief        |
| Educational content                   | Patient, plainspoken, wit dialed down, zero condescension |
| Account/tax reminders                 | Calm, clear, matter-of-fact, reassuring; no nagging       |
| When the client owes money / bad news | Serious, candid, shame-free, fully warm; no jokes         |

## *Vocabulary*

**Words we use:** clarity, breathing room, plan, real numbers, set up, sort out, on your side, no shame, here's the deal.

**Words we avoid:** wealth journey, financial freedom (overused), leverage, robust, holistic solutions, "as per," synergize, hustle, grind.

How we say common things:

| INSTEAD OF                                          | TIDEWATER SAYS                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Maximize your tax efficiency."                     | "Keep more of what you earned. Legally, obviously."                                           |
| "We offer comprehensive financial solutions."       | "We help you figure out what to do with your money, and stop dreading April."                 |
| "You have failed to submit required documentation." | "We're still missing a couple things to file for you. Two-minute fix, here's what we need."   |
| "Per our records, your balance is past due."        | "Heads up: this one's overdue. No judgment, let's just get it sorted. Here are your options." |

**Mechanics:** Contractions, always. Oxford comma, yes. Sentence-case headers. Emoji: rarely, and never in anything money-serious. Exclamation points: one per page, max, we are calm, not caffeinated.

*Voice in Action — Before & After*

A real snippet, written the generic way and the Tidewater way.

**Before (generic):**

“*At Tidewater & Co., we are passionate about empowering creative entrepreneurs to achieve financial freedom through our innovative, holistic suite of planning solutions.*”

**After (on-brand):**

“*You are great at the thing you do. You are, by your own admission, a disaster at the money part. That is fine, that is literally our job. We will set up a plan in plain English, handle the parts that make you panic, and make tax season a non-event. No shame, no jargon, no lectures.*”

Same company. One of them you would hire.

## CHAPTER SEVEN: A SECOND EXAMPLE, A VERY DIFFERENT VOICE — BRACE

To prove the framework works across registers, here is a second filled-in voice for a brand that should sound nothing like Tidewater. **Brace** is a fictional strength-training app for people over fifty who are tired of being talked to like they are fragile.

**Voice in one sentence:** Brace sounds like a no-nonsense coach who respects you too much to coddle you, direct, encouraging, a little tough, never patronizing.

### Traits:

- **Direct:** we say the thing without padding. This does NOT mean harsh or drill-sergeant.
- **Respectful:** we treat the reader as capable. This does NOT mean flattering or soft.
- **Motivating:** we make you want to show up. This does NOT mean hype, hustle-culture, or fake urgency.
- **Grounded:** we deal in what is real and proven. This does NOT mean dry or joyless.

### Beliefs:

- Age is not fragility. Most over-fifty fitness content insults its audience by assuming the opposite.
- Strength is independence. The real goal is not aesthetics, it is carrying your own groceries at eighty.
- Consistency beats intensity. We would rather you do the small thing forever than the heroic thing for a week.

**Human comparison:** Brace is the coach who believes in you more than you do, but NOT the influencer screaming "no excuses," and NOT the gentle wellness voice treating you like glass.

**A swap, Brace-style:**

| INSTEAD OF                     | BRACE SAYS                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Gentle movement for seniors." | "Real strength training. You are not fragile, and we are not going to treat you like you are." |
| "Don't overdo it!"             | "Push to the edge of hard, not past it. You will know the difference; trust it."               |

Notice that Brace and Tidewater share zero personality, yet both were built with the identical four-part foundation, the same shadow-clause technique, the same swap tables. That is the point. The framework is the constant. The voice it produces is whatever is true about the brand.

## CHAPTER EIGHT: ROLLING IT OUT TO A TEAM

A voice document that lives in a folder is worthless. Here is how to make a whole team actually sound like one person.

**Run a one-hour voice workshop, not a memo.** Walk the team through the doc, then do live reps: take three real pieces of existing copy and rewrite them together using the swap tables. People learn voice by doing it once with you in the room, not by reading a PDF.

**Build a "voice check" into your existing review.** Whatever your approval process is, add one question: "Does this sound like us?" with the doc open. The document only works if someone is empowered to say "that is off-voice" and point to the page.

**Make onboarding include the voice doc.** Every new hire, employee or freelancer, reads it in their first week and rewrites one sample as practice. Voice consistency is mostly a hiring-and-onboarding problem disguised as a writing problem.

**Keep a living swap table.** Every time someone writes a great on-brand line or catches an off-voice one, add it to the "How We Say Common Things" table. The document should get more useful every month, not freeze on the day it was finished.

**Build It:** Write the agenda for your one-hour voice workshop, and add the single voice-check question to your current review process today.

## CHAPTER NINE: TEACHING THE VOICE TO AI

Your team is not the only one writing in your voice now. The tools are too, and by default they all sound like the same agreeable, over-polished, em-dash-happy intern. A voice document is the best defense, because it is exactly the instruction set an AI needs.

**Feed it the document, not adjectives.** "Write this in a friendly, professional tone" gets you the default sludge. Paste in your one-sentence voice, your traits with their shadow clauses, your words-we-avoid list, and three or four of your best before-and-after swaps, then ask for the copy. The shadow clauses and the swaps do the heavy lifting; they teach the model your borders.

**Make the no-fly list explicit.** Tell it, in writing, the exact words to never use. This is the single highest-impact instruction you can give, because the generic words are the model's favorites and yours are not.

**Always edit the output against the doc.** AI gets you to a fast first draft in roughly your voice. It does not get you to *on*-voice. Run the draft through your own swap tables and read it aloud. The document is the rubric; the human is still the editor.

Used this way, the same voice doc that keeps your team consistent keeps your tools consistent, which matters more every year.

**Build It:** Write a reusable "voice prompt", a single block of text containing your one-sentence voice, traits with shadow clauses, the avoid list, and four swaps, that you can paste in front of any AI request.

## CHAPTER TEN: BUILDING, MAINTAINING, AND DEFENDING THE DOC

You have the framework, two models to copy, and a method for capture, rollout, and tooling. Three notes on making it last.

**Keep it to one usable document.** A forty-page brand bible nobody opens is worthless. The version people actually use is tight: the one-sentence voice, the traits with their shadow clauses, the tone table, the swap lists, the mechanics calls. If it does not fit in something a new hire can absorb in fifteen minutes, cut it down.

**Lead with examples, always.** Every rule needs a before-and-after or a swap. Teams do not follow principles; they follow patterns. The example is the rule.

**Defend it from the committee.** The moment a voice succeeds, people will want to soften it, add a hedge, remove a stance, make it "a little more professional." That is the beige carpet creeping back in. The whole value of the document is that it lets you say "that is off-voice" and point to the page. A voice with no borders is not a voice. It is a vibe, and vibes do not survive contact with a busy team.

“

*The goal is not a beautiful document. It is a brand that sounds like one specific, recognizable person no matter who is holding the keyboard. The document is just how you keep your promise to sound like yourself.*



# APPENDIX: THE FILL-IN TEMPLATE

Copy this and complete it for any brand. When every blank is filled, you have a working voice guide.

**1. Voice in one sentence:** "We sound like \_\_\_\_."

**2. Traits (3 to 5), each with a border:**

- \_\_\_\_ : this means \_\_\_\_\_. This does NOT mean \_\_\_\_\_.
- (repeat)

**3. Beliefs (3 to 5):** "We believe \_\_\_\_\_."

**4. Human comparison:** "If we were a person, we would be \_\_\_\_\_, but NOT \_\_\_\_\_."

**5. Tone sliders:** mark your default on Formal/Casual, Serious/Playful, Reserved/Bold, Warm/Matter-of-fact.

**6. Tone-by-situation table:** marketing, onboarding, errors, billing, support, bad news.

**7. Words we use / Words we avoid.**

**8. How we say common things:** your ten most frequent messages, in your voice.

**9. Mechanics:** contractions, Oxford comma, header case, emoji policy, exclamation budget.

**10. Three before-and-after examples.**

**11. The voice prompt** for AI tools.

## KEEP GOING

You now have everything you need to build a voice from scratch, two worked examples to model, and a method for capturing, rolling out, and defending it.

If you are a solo operator and the brand you most need to voice is *you*, start with **Write Yourself Into the Room**, the personal-brand companion to this playbook, with positioning frameworks and bio templates.

And if you are a founder or creative whose own identity is still mid-rewrite, voice is hard to build on shifting ground, **The Reinvention Workbook** does that deeper work.

Find more, and inquire about done-for-you voice work, at **mkparrish.com**.

Most brands settle for sounding like everyone. You are not going to. You have the document now.

— MK Parrish

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